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There's a saying among screenwriters that third-act problems are first-act problems, which is to say that if you're having trouble with how your story ends, the issue is probably with how it began. The characters in *The Four Seasons*, whose second season is now streaming on Netflix, are, statistically speaking, entering their third acts, the period after youth and parenthood where their lives are once again their own. But unlike a screenwriter, they can't go back and fix the mistakes they made in their first acts. They're stuck in the present, facing down an unsatisfying conclusion and forced to wonder: Is this really how it ends?

In [the show's first season](#), Nick (Steve Carell) coped with third-act panic in the most predictable of ways: by leaving his wife, Anne (Kerri Kenney-Silver), for Ginny (Erika Henningsen), a woman half his age. But Nick's new life didn't last long, and his friends, longtime couples Kate (Tina Fey) and Jack (Will Forte) and Danny (Colman Domingo) and Claude (Marco Calvani), start the second season mourning his death, their envy for his brief spate of freedom muted by the knowledge of how it ended. In the first season, Jack's unashamed pursuit of his own happiness upset his friends' complacency, the way they'd settled into a comfortable groove and let minor disappointments pile up like unpaid parking tickets. In the second, their lives are unsettled, and questions long closed are open again. But revisiting those fundamental issues—Where are we going to live? Should we maybe adopt? Do I even want to be married again?—is unnerving enough to make them think they might have been better off when they were just content with what they already had.

The new season's structure remains the same as the first's: two episodes for each season of the year, with the couples vacationing in a different locale each time. But the show's emotional center has shifted ever so slightly. The first was centered on Kate and Jack's marriage, the long-term heterosexual couple caught between the Scylla of Nick and Anne's divorce and the Charybdis of Danny and Claude's child-free existence. But the heart of the second is Kate's friendship with Danny, and the prickly camaraderie between Fey and Domingo, who take to each other as if they, and not just their characters, have been friends for years.

Fey and co-creators Tracey Wigfield and Lang Fisher take advantage of their four-hour running time to rearrange their characters in different combinations, and to ensure none of them gets short shrift. Fey's house style is famously joke-dense, but the series doesn't succumb to the temptation to rush through uncomfortable conversations to get to the next one-liner, and it's both richer and more deeply funny because of the time it takes. In the Alan Alda movie from which the series was adapted, Ginny was essentially a bubble-headed punch line, and even in the show's first season, she was largely present for the sake of contrast: a way of making the characters in their 50s both feel ancient and thank god they were no longer in their 30s. But without Nick to come between them, his ex-wife and widowed girlfriend find a surprising measure of common ground, especially when it comes to bringing up Ginny's baby. Even as she's searching for a new role to transition into—the 2.0 version of herself—Anne finds slipping back into an old role surprisingly easy, even if there's some generational conflict on matters child-related. (The Gen X cohort doesn't find "Cove" a suitable name for a boy-to-be—or, really, for anyone.) Danny and Claude feel like they dodged a bullet, kid-wise: As Danny puts it, "We weren't willing to give up our youth and freedom the way you all did." But as Kate admits, "We weren't using any of that stuff anyway."

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Unlike the caricature of old age offered up by [The Boroughs](#), *The Four Seasons* finds a way to own up to the limitations of middle age without succumbing to them. These characters might have decades left, but they also might, like Nick, be dead tomorrow, and however open the windows of possibility might still be, they can feel them starting to swing shut. “Every decision feels like I’m trying to stick the landing on my entire fucking life,” Danny says, and it’s clear that sense of finality is working its way through the others around him as well. (As Anne quips in morbid response, “Well, at least it’s almost done.”) Kate and Jack’s relationship is on more solid ground than it was, but that’s worrisome in its own way: What if staying together forever allows them to grow more and more “weird” without even noticing, until they’ve cut themselves off from the rest of the world entirely? As for Claude and Danny, they start to question whether life has anything left in store but an endless series of kitchen renovations, redoing the same room over and over until the final estimate comes.

The Four Seasons doesn’t suggest that the good times are over once you enter the stage of life when just sleeping in the wrong position can give you back pain for days. But it does warn that other things can end if you don’t stay alert. “You know, when you hit your 50s, you just sort of never feel joy again?” Anne asks at one turning point, and while Fey swoops in with a zinger to make sure the audience knows it’s a joke, it’s meant to be the kind that leaves a mark. These characters aren’t done with joy, but it’s more complicated than it used to be, because they can feel the chances they haven’t taken slipping away, and even the chances they do take come at the expense of other choices. “Maybe we don’t get to do everything,” Danny ruefully reflects. But the show’s warm and complex portrait of love and friendship underlines that what we do matters more than what we don’t, and that fall and even winter can be just as beautiful as spring.

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